Three vantage points of the Cold War: Hobsbawm, Gaddis, and Jervis

For more than forty years after the Second World War, the United States and the Soviet Union were locked in the Cold War, a struggle described by Hobsbawm (1995) as "a Third World War, though a very peculiar one" (p. 226). It "utterly dominated the international scene in the second half" of the century (Hobsbawm, 1995, p. 226) and has been the subject of many works across various academic genres. Three of these are the 'Cold War' chapter of Eric Hobsbawm's 1995 book, *Age of Extremes*; John Lewis Gaddis' (1986) article on the stability of the bipolar world order, 'The Long Peace: Elements of Stability in the Postwar International System'; and 'Was the Cold War a Security Dilemma?' by Robert Jervis (2001), an analysis drawing on international relations theory. Comparison of these accounts shows how far the period in which each author wrote, the information available to them, the questions they asked, and the theoretical frameworks they applied shaped their account of the same events. Hobsbawm, Gaddis, and Jervis largely agreed on the observable aspects of the Cold War, such as frozen European borders and the threat of nuclear annihilation preventing direct war between the United States and the Soviet Union. The three diverged on the fundamental drive behind the superpower rivalry and the effects of the arms race, but converged, by different routes, on the Soviet part in ending the war and the instability its end left behind.

The three accounts

Hobsbawm's (1995) account was written shortly after the dissolution of the Soviet Union. His object was not to narrate *what* happened, but "to understand and explain *why* things turned out the way they did" (Hobsbawm, 1995, p. 3). From this frame, Hobsbawm (1995) argued that, despite forty years of apocalyptic rhetoric, "no imminent danger of world war existed" (p. 226). He maintained that the confrontational relationship between the two powers was not entirely ideological and would probably have developed regardless, given the international situation after the Second World War (p. 233). After the initial period of animosity and the crises of the early 1960s, relations between the two powers settled and tensions gradually reduced (p. 243). Hobsbawm (1995) argued that this led to the Soviet downfall: "what defeated … the USSR was not confrontation but détente" (p. 251). Isolation had previously protected the Soviet economy, and its "increasingly evident and crippling economic defects" (Hobsbawm, 1995, p. 251) became threatening only after exposure to capitalist markets. By the 1980s, Western technological and economic superiority was incalculable (p. 247), and

though the arms race that followed the mid-1970s resumption of militaristic and aggressive rhetoric overstretched both superpowers, the capitalist market could weather the debt while the Soviet Union collapsed (p. 250).

In contrast, Gaddis (1986) wrote before the end of the Cold War and sought to explain why bipolar superpower rivalry had produced the “Long Peace”, the longest stretch of great-power stability of the century (p. 142). He was careful to present his conclusions as “a series of speculations” (Gaddis, 1986, p. 104) and acknowledged the limited availability of information. Gaddis (1986) argued that no one had designed the post-1945 order (p. 99); the nations of the post-war era had “lucked into” (p. 110) a system that had preserved order twice as long as the settlement after the First World War (p. 100). He argued that structure “can under certain circumstances impose stability” even when the conditions for it seemed poor (Gaddis, 1986, p. 105). He also highlighted further constraints on the two powers: a gradual moderation of each side’s ideological ambitions (p. 131) and a set of implicit “rules” that grew “out of a mixture of custom, precedent, and mutual interest” to govern their interactions (Gaddis, 1986, p. 133).

Written a decade after the Soviet collapse, Jervis’ (2001) article evaluated whether the conflict could be explained as a security dilemma, in which the measures one state takes for its own security leave others less secure, so that conflict arises from the interaction between states and not only from differing goals (p. 36). This required analysis of the superpowers’ intentions as well as their behaviour, since the same actions could stem from either offensive or defensive motives (p. 38). Jervis (2001) concluded that although the Cold War contained elements of a security dilemma, “the root of the conflict at best was a clash of social systems” (p. 58). Maintaining the status quo was not the Soviet aim; Soviet leaders chiefly feared the West insofar as it might obstruct their ambitions, which is “quite different from what the security dilemma has in mind” (Jervis, 2001, p. 58). The United States, by contrast, would, until the final years of the conflict, have traded further gains for a high degree of security (p. 52), but since a frozen status quo was not on offer, it too often adopted offensive tactics (p. 59).

Agreement on deterrence and restraints

Despite their different vantage points and purposes, the three histories agreed on several points. The most obvious of these is their agreement that the emergence of nuclear weapons and the threat of mutually assured destruction made direct war between the superpowers “the

equivalent of a suicide pact" (Hobsbawm, 1995, p. 229). Gaddis (1986) described nuclear deterrence as "the most important behavioral mechanism" sustaining the post-war system (p. 123), and Jervis (2001) found that the fear of nuclear war "not only increased international tension … but also produced restraint" (p. 57). This consensus is unsurprising, given that "entire generations grew up under the shadow of global nuclear battles" (Hobsbawm, 1995, p. 226). Gaddis (1986) similarly argued that evidence of Hiroshima and Nagasaki had left his generation acutely aware of the potential destruction nuclear war would wreak (p. 122). The nuclear threat was written into the implicit rules Gaddis identified, one of which was to use nuclear weapons "only as an ultimate resort" (Gaddis, 1986, p. 136).

Hobsbawm and Jervis, though less systematic than Gaddis, described similar tacit constraints that the two powers imposed on themselves. Until the mid-1970s, in Hobsbawm's (1995) account, both sides "accepted the uneven division of the world" and sought to resolve issues without direct military contact, despite the empty "radio histrionics" of the Americans (p. 228). He pointed to East Germany in 1953 and Hungary in 1956, where the United States stood back while the Soviets re-established control after a revolt, as evidence of a "tacit agreement to treat the Cold War as a Cold Peace" (Hobsbawm, 1995, p. 228). Gaddis (1986) cited the same case of Hungary in 1956 as an example of each power respecting the other's sphere of influence, and showed that the restraint ran both ways, as Moscow likewise did not resist the restoration of American influence in Iran in 1953 or Guatemala in 1954 (p. 134). Dividing Germany, Jervis (2001) found, gave each side "a stake in the status quo" (p. 52), and a European settlement both sides could accept was broadly in place by the early 1950s (p. 55). This consensus, however, concerned what the two powers did rather than why they did it; as Jervis (2001) observed, the same behaviour could stem from ambition or from fear (p. 38), and it is on questions of motive and consequence that the three accounts diverge.

Divergence on motive and the arms race

The authors diverged most clearly on the motivations and goals of the two superpowers, and each explanation was shaped by the question its author sought to answer. Hobsbawm (1995) held that it was "now evident" that the USSR had not been expansionist or aggressive (p. 232). Gaddis' (1986) question was why the peace had lasted, and while he conceded that both powers could be seen as intensely ideological (p. 126), he suggested that American restraint in its war aims seemed to show the interests of the system generally outweighing ideology (p. 131). Jervis (2001), testing whether the conflict was a security dilemma, needed

to establish each side's intent, and his findings sat uneasily with both, since Stalin had been "quite willing to take advantage of opportunities to expand" (p. 45), and his successors found the status quo unacceptable partly because Communist doctrine "instilled confidence that change was inevitable" (p. 47). Some of this evidence came from newly declassified Soviet records (Jervis, 2001, p. 46), although Jervis conceded that these "cannot refute the revisionists' claims" (p. 43) that the United States would have opposed any rising power and pursued open markets for American business regardless of whether the Soviet Union existed. The disagreement over motive therefore reflects evidence as well as purpose. Hobsbawm and Gaddis largely inferred Soviet intentions from conduct, whereas Jervis could test them against those records, which most directly challenged Hobsbawm's verdict.

Hobsbawm, Gaddis, and Jervis also differed on the effects of the arms race. Writing before the Soviet collapse, Gaddis (1986) argued that wars rarely develop "from the direct effects of arms races" (p. 120), and that nuclear armaments had "on balance, a stabilizing effect" (p. 123), although he acknowledged that deterrence might have been as effective with vastly smaller arsenals (p. 123). Hobsbawm (1995), in contrast, judged the arms race by its economic cost to the Soviet Union. He called it a pointless endeavour and argued that, through two decades of rising military spending, the Soviet regime had "begun to bankrupt itself" (Hobsbawm, 1995, p. 246). Both governments, Jervis (2001) argued, armed themselves out of fear of inferiority rather than ambition, and "the process of acquiring additional arms generated conflict rather than merely reflecting it" (p. 56). From the mid-1960s, the race itself "may also have constituted a security dilemma" (Jervis, 2001, p. 55). For Gaddis, then, the arms race did little to make war more likely; for Hobsbawm (1995), it was a ruinous folly whose "sinister absurdity" (p. 249) one or both superpowers had to recognise before the Cold War could end; and for Jervis, it fed the very hostility it was meant to guard against.

Convergent endings

On the end of the Cold War, however, the three accounts align more closely, though they reach their conclusions in different ways. Hobsbawm and Jervis both credited the Soviet side more with ending the conflict. Jervis (2001) argued that the Cold War could not have truly ended until the Soviet Union itself changed and abandoned its class-struggle view of international politics (p. 60). Hobsbawm (1995) also looked to Moscow, but for a different reason: "it was probably easier for a Soviet leader to take this initiative … because the Cold

War had never been seen by Moscow in the crusading terms common in Washington" (p. 249). To Jervis, then, ending the war required the Soviets to give up a core tenet of their ideology; to Hobsbawm, it was their lesser ideological obstinacy that made it easier for them to reach out, though harder to be believed (p. 249).

Gaddis could not know how the Cold War would end, and instead considered how the bipolar system might be tested. He noted that great-power status is "transitory" (Gaddis, 1986, p. 141) and that sooner or later one or the other would decline; preserving stability might then require each to take a stake in the prosperity of its rival, since "international systems, like tangoes, require at least two reasonably active and healthy participants" (p. 142). Hobsbawm's (1995) history of the aftermath described much of what Gaddis had feared: the end of the Cold War left the world in "disarray and partial collapse" and the American idea of a new order built on the single remaining superpower "rapidly proved unrealistic" (p. 255). Gaddis' warning was thus borne out, though less in the danger he stressed, a declining power whose behaviour might become "erratic, even desperate" (Gaddis, 1986, p. 141), than in the caution that followed his metaphor, to consider what would replace the dance before letting it end (p. 142). In Hobsbawm's (1995) account, nothing did (p. 255).

Conclusion

Hobsbawm, Gaddis, and Jervis largely agreed on the conditions that bounded the Cold War and on how the superpowers behaved within them. Nuclear weapons restrained the two powers from direct war, and both respected the division of Europe and each other's spheres of influence. They differed, however, in their explanations of the motivations of the two powers and of the effects of the arms race. Much of that divergence follows from when each account was written and what it set out to explain: Gaddis why the post-war peace had lasted, and Hobsbawm, after the collapse of the USSR, why things had turned out as they did. Newly opened Soviet records, though incomplete, let Jervis test intentions more directly than either of the others could. Period and information do not explain everything; Hobsbawm and Jervis both gave Moscow the larger part in ending the war, yet their reasons drew on different interpretations of Soviet ideology. Gaddis' caution about what would replace the bipolar order was also borne out in Hobsbawm's account of the disorder that followed the end of the Cold War. Together, the three accounts show that the period in which a history is written shapes the evidence available to its author, while the questions and frameworks the author brings affect how that evidence is interpreted.

References

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